

CONSISTENT QUALITY ACROSS 6,000+ SERVICE TOUCHPOINTS

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CASE CONTEXT & OBJECTIVE: This is an independently developed educational Quality Engineering case study based on publicly available information and TQM principles. It explores how a large service network can maintain a defined level of service quality while allowing flexibility for local conditions. It does not represent an official Maruti Suzuki project or internal company study, nor does it claim that every service touchpoint currently has a quality issue.

01 THE QUALITY CHALLENGE ACROSS A LARGE SERVICE NETWORK

Maintaining consistent service quality becomes a different challenge when a company operates through a very large number of service touchpoints. A customer visiting a service centre in a major city may have access to different infrastructure, resources and support compared with a customer visiting a smaller city or town. These differences can naturally affect how a service is delivered.

Location is therefore one factor that can influence consistency, but it is not the only one. Customer expectations and the way customers judge their service experience can also differ. At the same time, differences in service methods, resource availability, training and local practices can create variation between touchpoints.

The challenge is not to make every service centre completely identical. The more practical objective is to ensure that every customer receives a defined level of quality, while allowing reasonable flexibility according to local conditions. This case therefore looks at a simple TQM question: how can a large service network maintain a common quality expectation while still responding to the realities of different locations?

02 ESTABLISHING A COMMON QUALITY STANDARD

The first step is to define a common minimum quality standard that every applicable service touchpoint is expected to meet. This standard provides a common direction across the network and creates a clear reference for measuring service performance.

However, standardization should not mean that every location must operate in exactly the same way. A smaller city may have different infrastructure or resource limitations compared with a major city. Therefore, the standard should define what level of quality must be maintained, while allowing suitable flexibility in how that level is achieved.

This approach creates a balance between consistency and local reality. The objective is not to remove every difference between locations, but to prevent those differences from creating an unacceptable difference in the customer's basic service experience.

03 MEASURING CONSISTENCY THROUGH MULTIPLE SOURCES

Once a common quality standard is defined, the next requirement is to measure whether it is actually being maintained. A single measurement cannot always provide a complete picture of service quality across such a large network.

Regular quality audits can show whether the expected process is being followed. Common performance indicators can help compare service performance across different touchpoints. Customer feedback and complaints provide another perspective by showing how the service is actually experienced.

These sources should therefore be considered together. A service centre may perform well during an internal audit while customers continue to report a particular issue. Similarly, a customer may be satisfied with the service even when a process gap is visible during an audit. Combining audit results, performance data and customer feedback provides a more balanced view of quality and helps identify where a genuine improvement opportunity exists.

04 IDENTIFYING QUALITY GAPS AND SHARING BEST PRACTICES

When a service touchpoint consistently performs below the expected standard, the first step should be to understand the reason behind the gap. The objective should not simply be to point out that performance is low, but to identify what support is actually required. Training and process support can be provided where the gap is related to knowledge, skills or process understanding. At the same time, high-performing service touchpoints can be studied to understand what they are doing differently.

Useful practices from these high-performing locations can then be shared with other service teams where they are relevant. This creates an environment in which one part of the network can learn from another instead of every location having to solve the same problem independently. The important point is that best practices should not be copied blindly. A practice that works well in one location may need adjustment before it can work effectively in another.

05 DEEPER ANALYSIS & PILOT IMPLEMENTATION	If a service touchpoint continues to perform below the required level even after training and support, the problem needs to be examined at a deeper level. The analysis should consider the process, people, resources and local operating conditions instead of assuming that the same reason exists everywhere. Similarly, when a high-performing touchpoint has a useful practice, its suitability for another location should first be understood. The practice can then be tested on a smaller scale before wider implementation. This pilot approach provides an opportunity to observe the result, identify practical difficulties and make necessary adjustments. If the practice performs consistently under the new conditions, it can then be extended to other relevant service touchpoints. This creates a practical balance between standardization and local flexibility.
06 FROM LOCAL COMPLAINTS TO NETWORK IMPROVEMENT	Customer complaints should not always be treated as isolated problems belonging to individual service centres. If the same type of complaint starts appearing across multiple touchpoints, it may indicate a common issue that requires a wider response. Pareto Analysis can be used to identify which complaint categories contribute most to the overall problem. Once the major area is identified, 5 Why Analysis can be used to understand the underlying reason. Where several possible causes are present, the Shainin Red X approach can help focus attention on the dominant source contributing to the observed variation. The purpose is to move from repeated local correction towards understanding whether a common cause exists across the network. Where a common cause is confirmed, the corrective action can also be considered at the network level rather than solving the same issue separately at every location.
07 PDCA, SIX SIGMA & CONTINUOUS MONITORING	The overall improvement process can be managed through the PDCA cycle. The problem and expected improvement are first planned, the proposed change is tested, the result is checked using process data and customer feedback, and the next action is decided based on the evidence. Six Sigma principles can provide additional support when deeper variation analysis is required. ISO 13053 can be referred to for the structured application of Six Sigma methodology, while ISO 18404 can provide a reference for Lean and Six Sigma competencies and their application. These standards should remain supporting references rather than becoming the focus of the case. The practical objective remains to understand variation, identify important causes, improve the process and verify whether the improvement is stable. After implementation, regular quality audits, common performance indicators and continuous customer feedback should continue to be monitored.
08 VALIDATION, STANDARDIZATION & SOP	An improvement should not be considered successful only because one performance indicator has improved. The result should be evaluated through a combination of quality audits, performance measures and customer feedback. If the improvement produces stable results, the successful practice can first be established as a standard reference practice. This allows other relevant service touchpoints to understand and learn from a proven approach. After its effectiveness and sustainability have been confirmed, the improved method can be converted into a formal Standard Operating Procedure (SOP). This ensures that the improvement becomes part of the normal service process rather than remaining a temporary corrective action. The same cycle can continue whenever a new quality gap appears. The goal is not to make every service centre identical, but to maintain a consistent level of quality while respecting the differences that exist between locations.

TQM TOOLS & METHODS APPLIED

- **Pareto Analysis:** Helps identify the few problem categories that contribute most to an overall issue, prioritizing the quality areas requiring greatest network attention.
- **5 Why Analysis:** A root-cause analysis method that repeatedly asks why a problem occurs until its underlying operational cause becomes clear.
- **Shainin Red X:** Focuses on identifying the dominant source of variation behind a quality issue when multiple contributing causes are present.
- **PDCA Cycle:** Provides the structured cycle (Plan, Do, Check, Act) for testing process changes on a small scale before network-wide rollout.
- **Customer Feedback / Voice of Customer:** Direct customer input used alongside audits and KPIs to verify that process changes translate into real service improvement.
- **ISO 13053 & ISO 18404:** International standards providing guidance on Six Sigma methodology implementation and Lean/Six Sigma competencies across the network.
- **Standardization & SOP:** Converts proven, stable improvements into formal Standard Operating Procedures to anchor high quality into daily operations.

“Quality becomes consistent when standards are shared, performance is measured, and improvement is continuously carried across the network.”

Educational Disclaimer: This case study has been independently developed for educational and learning purposes as part of the #100DaysOfTQM initiative. It applies TQM and Quality Engineering concepts to a Maruti Suzuki service-quality context using independent analysis and publicly available information. It does not represent an official Maruti Suzuki project, internal company process or company-approved solution. The author is not representing or claiming affiliation with Maruti Suzuki through this case study.